14. Hunting, trapping and using animals

Oracle OS guide. Manuals in the library: FM 21-76 (traps and snares), "Camp and Trail Methods", "The Trapper's Guide", "Fishing" (Oracle guide), "Animals" (Oracle guide). In normal times, follow hunting and animal-welfare laws; traps are for food only, checked every day, never on paths people use.

Principles

- Small game (rabbit, hare, squirrel, birds, fish) gives more calories for the effort than big game. Fishing and traps work while you do something else.
- **Read sign**: runs (beaten paths through grass), tracks, fresh droppings, burrows, feeding and drinking spots. Set traps on runs between burrow and food/water, at narrow points.
- **Many traps** (10–20) raise the odds; check at dawn and dusk. Minimise human scent (gloves, smoke parts over a fire, don't over-handle).
- Never leave traps abandoned.

Simple traps (details and drawings in FM 21-76)

- **Simple snare**: fine wire or strong cord with a running noose; ~10 cm loop for rabbit, 10 cm off the ground (a fist), on the run, anchored to a stake or firm branch. Small sticks guide the animal into the loop.
- **Spring snare**: noose tied to a bent sapling held by a trigger; when tripped it lifts the animal.
- **Deadfall (figure-4)**: flat stone/log propped on a baited 3-stick trigger; for small rodents.
- **Bird traps**: snares on perch branches; upturned baskets with a trigger stick.
- **Fish trap**: funnel basket of willow or a cut bottle; stone weirs in streams (see Fishing).

Hunting

- **Self bow**: yew, ash, elm, hazel or willow 1.5–1.8 m, season for weeks; fibre/sinew string. Arrows from straight shoots, bird feathers, a sharpened fire-hardened tip, bone or metal. Practise a lot before you need it.
- **Sling**, **spear**, **throwing sticks** for birds and small game.
- Stalking: downwind, slowly, freeze when the animal looks, use cover. Best times: dawn and dusk.
- Kill quickly and humanely; never wound without following up.

Preparing the meat (safely)

1. Bleed at once (head down, cut the neck vessels).
2. **Gut**: shallow cut from breastbone to pelvis without piercing the intestines or bladder; remove the organs; keep heart, liver (if healthy — no spots/cysts) and kidneys.

3. **Skin**: rabbits — cut round the hind legs and pull the skin off like a sock; larger animals — cuts down the legs and centre line, separate with the knife.
4. Cool the carcass in the shade, away from flies (cloth/bag).
5. **Cook thoroughly** (rabbit, wild boar, bear: risk of tularaemia and trichinosis). Gloves when skinning wild rabbits; don't eat animals that seemed sick or sluggish.
6. Don't live on lean meat alone (rabbit) for weeks — "rabbit starvation": add fat and carbohydrates.

Use everything

- Hide: tan it (see "Textiles and leather").
- Sinew: dry and shred for bowstrings and sewing.
- Bones: needles, fish hooks, tools, broth; bone ash as fertiliser (phosphorus).
- Fat: render into tallow (candles, soap, preserving).
- Preserving meat: dry in thin strips in sun/wind or cold smoke (jerky), salt, or hot-smoke.